Stayman

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Stayman is a convention used for locating a 4-4 major suit fit after partner opens 1NT. It is one of the oldest and most widely used conventions in the world, since a major suit contract is often preferable to no-trumps. A 2♣ response to 1NT normally shows at least a game-invitational hand with one or both majors.

Some examples of game-invitational (or stronger) hands opposite a 15-17 1NT:

♠AT98 ♥KJT9 ♦532 ♣64	♠KQJ52 ♥Q432 ♦T97 ♣J	♠QJ32 ♥AQ987 ♦5 ♣T32	♠KJT3 ♥K4 ♦A532 ♣876

Opener's Rebids

After 1NT: 2♣, opener's rebids are as follows.

Opener's Rebid	Meaning
2♦	Denies a 4-card major.
2♥	4 hearts, may have 4 spades.
2♠	4 spades, denies 4 hearts.

Responder's rebids after 2♦

Responder's Rebid	Meaning
2♥	4 spades and 5 hearts, invitational. Non-forcing.
2♠	5 spades and 4 hearts, invitational. Non-forcing.
2NT	Invitational.
3♣	Game forcing with at least 5 clubs (usually 6). Does not guarantee a 4-card major.
3♦	Game forcing with at least 5 diamonds (usually 6). Does not guarantee a 4-card major.
3♥	4 spades and 5 hearts, game-forcing.
3♠	5 spades and 4 hearts, game-forcing.
3NT	Signoff.
4♥	4 spades and 6 hearts, signoff.
4♠	6 spades and 4 hearts, signoff.

4NT	Quantitative, invites 6NT.

Responder's rebids after 2♥

Responder's Rebid	Meaning
2♠	5 spades and 4 hearts, invitational. Non-forcing.
2NT	4 spades, fewer than 4 hearts, invitational. Opener can: • Pass with a minimum • Sign off in 3♠ with 4 spades and a minimum • Bid 4♠ with 4 spades and a maximum • Bid 3NT with a maximum
3♣	Game-forcing with at least 5 clubs (usually 6). Does not guarantee a 4-card major.
3♦	Game-forcing with at least 5 diamonds (usually 6). Does not guarantee a 4-card major.
3♥	4 hearts, invitational.
3♠	Game-forcing with at least 5 spades and 4 hearts.
3NT	4 spades and fewer than 4 hearts. Opener can pass or bid 4♠ with 4 spades.
4♥	Signoff.
4NT	Quantitative, invites 6NT.

Responder's rebids after 2♠

Responder's Rebid	Meaning
2NT	Invitational.
3♣	Game-forcing with at least 5 clubs (usually 6). Does not guarantee a 4-card major.
3♦	Game-forcing with at least 5 diamonds (usually 6). Does not guarantee a 4-card major.
3♥	4 spades and 5 hearts, game-forcing.
3♠	4 spades, invitational.
3NT	Signoff with 4 hearts.
4♠	Signoff.
4NT	Quantitative, invites 6NT.

In Competition

- If 1NT is doubled for penalty, 2♣ is a natural signoff, not Stayman.
- If 1NT is overcalled, responder can cue-bid the opponent's suit to ask for a 4-card major. If the opponents have overcalled in one major, a cue-bid asks partner for the other major. Opener can rebid 3♦, if that bid is available, to deny a 4-card major; otherwise, he rebids 3NT.
- If 2♣ is doubled, opener can pass with 4 clubs and no 4-card major. Redouble shows 5 (or 4 good) clubs and no 4-card major. 2♦, 2♥, and 2♠ are normal responses to Stayman.
- If 2♣ is overcalled, opener can double for penalty or show a 4-card major at the two-level. With all other hands, he passes.

Other Considerations

- Stayman is usually not used with 4333 shape, since this distribution tends to be more conducive to playing in no-trumps.
- In his book "50 Winning Duplicate Tips", Australian expert Ron Klinger recommends bypassing Stayman with a balanced 4432 when holding a combined 28-30 HCP. At pairs, the no-trump contract will typically yield the same number of tricks as a major-suit game, and offers an extra 10 points (e.g. 660 vs. 650).
- Stayman is also used after a 1NT overcall, opening bids of 2NT or 3NT, and notrump rebids after a opening 2♣ (artificial and strong) bid.

  2NT : 3♣

  3NT : 4♣

  2♣ : 2♦
  2NT : 3♣

  2♣ : 2♦
  3NT: 4♣
- Stayman is also used when responder is interested in a minor-suit slam but does NOT have a 4-card major. With a 5+ clubs or diamonds and 10+ HCP, responder can bid 2♣ Stayman, planning to rebid his minor suit naturally.

Examples

Opener	Responder
♠KT93	♠AJ5
♥AKJ3	♥QT52
♦J8	♦A5
♣A52	♣9763

Opener	Responder
1NT	2♣ (1)
2♥ (2)	4♥ (3)
Pass	

1. Stayman
2. 4 hearts
3. Signing off in game

Opener	Responder
♠KT93	♠AJ85
♥AKJ3	♥Q5
♦T8	♦Q652
♣A52	♣976

Opener	Responder
1NT	2♣ (1)
2♥ (2)	2NT (3)
3♠ (4)	

1. Stayman
2. 4 hearts
3. Inviting game
4. 4 spades, signing off. Opener knows responder must hold 4 spades to have bid Stayman.

Opener	Responder
♠KJ2	♠Q965
♥QT7	♥AK543
♦AK97	♦Q6
♣A64	♣T9

Opener	Responder
1NT	2♣ (1)
2♦ (2)	3♥ (3)
4♥ (4)	Pass

1. Stayman
2. Denying a 4-card major
3. 5 hearts and 4 spades, game-forcing
4. Bidding game with a maximum

Opener	Responder
♠K52	♠Q9
♥AQ97	♥KT
♦AK54	♦QT9
♣76	♣AKT982

Opener	Responder
1NT	2♣ (1)
2♥ (2)	3♣ (3)
3NT (4)	Pass

1. Stayman
2. 4 hearts
3. 5+ clubs, game-forcing
4. Signing off with poor club support

Origins

Stayman is named for the late American expert Sam Stayman. The convention was actually invented by his partner George Rapee in 1944, but it was Stayman who popularized the convention shortly thereafter.

See also

- Crawling Stayman
  A convention for showing a weak hand with 4-4 shape in the majors.
- Double-Barreled Stayman
  A convention for distinguishing non-forcing and forcing Stayman hands.
- Garbage Stayman
  A method of showing a weak 3-suiter short in clubs.
- Keri Response to 1NT
  A scientific alternative to Stayman by expert Ron Klinger.